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Shasvin

A Descriptive Grammar of the Language of the Shasvin Archipelago

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Notice

The present grammar was originally redacted by the Senate's Interstellar Language Bureau during the late colonial administration of AR-29G and describes the literary register historically employed throughout the Shasvin Archipelago, mainly the variety spoken on Sumi.

Assessment

Following intense evaluation under Directive 77-19, the Senate has determined that the limited availability of external reference materials, the conservative orthographic conventions, and the nonexistence of contemporary speakers outisde of AR-29G are all factors that make Shasvin adequate for encrypted communication.

Accordingly, the literary register documented in this volume has been designated the normative basis for *Standard Shasvin* (*Saspine Lahapek*, Shasvin: [ˈɕaspɪn ˈlapɛj]), and will be used as an auxiliary language within the Senate and its organizations.

Readers are advised that contemporary varieties spoken on AR-29G are likely to differ substantially from the register presented herein, which was recorded two millennia ago.

Authorized under Directive 77-19,
Office of Auxiliary Languages

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Contents

1 Introduction

Shasvin (*Nahali Saspin*, Shasvin: [naj ˈɕaspɪn]) is the main language of the Shasvin Tanayu Archipelago and the associated harbor settlements along its migration route on AR-29G.

Shasvin constitutes a dialectal continuum across its various regions, with the varieties spoken in Harbors being the most distinctive. The variety described in this document is that of Sumi City, carried by a Tanayu called Sumi. Still, it is supplemented where appropriate by observations of other dialects.

Sumi is the only socially-adult Tanayu in the archipelago, while the others remain socially juvenile, tailing behind it. The social structure of the Tanayu is mirrored in that of humans, making Sumi City the most culturally and economically influencial Shasvin-speaking city. Its dialect is widely understood and the basis for the literary and written forms, where official documents are concerned.

As with all languages in AR-29G, Shasvin exhibits a wide range of Kupina Hala borrowings, which entered the language after the Shasvin people adopted Hiwariism.

The present document provides a comprehensive descriptive account of Shasvin phonology, morphology, syntax, and orthographic practice, based on direct field observations conducted between 1881 and 1888 AA in accordance with the archival and validation standards of the Senate's Interstellar Language Bureau.

2 Phonology

The following phonology has 45 phonemes—26 consonants and 19 vowels—and is based on the Sumi dialect. Speakers of other varieties, however, may merge or alter some of these phonemes.

2.1 Consonants

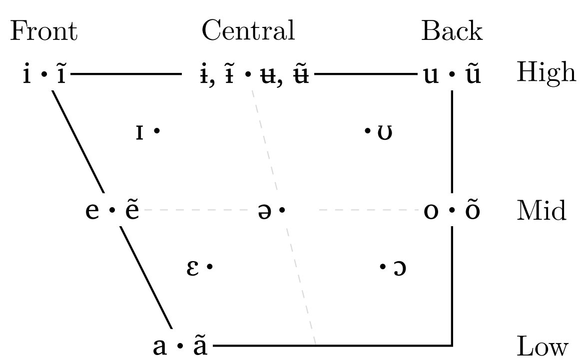
The consonant inventory is presented in Table 1. Note that the alveolar tap [ɾ] will be represented by /r/ in the table and throughout the document for simplicity reasons.

	Labial	Alveolar	Palatal	Glottal
Plosive	$\mathrm{p^h}$ p b	$\mathrm{t^h}$ t d		$\mathrm{k^h}$ k g
Nasal	m	n	ɲ	
Fricative	ɸ	s z	ɕ ʑ	h
Affricate		t͡s d͡z	t͡ɕ d͡ʑ	
Sonorant	w	l r	j	

Table 1: Consonant Inventory

2.2 Vowels

The vowel system consists of strong, weak, and nasalized sets, with two vowels missing a strengthened version. The following vowel diagram illustrates the relative phonetic positions.



[1]: Most speakers merge the high-central rounded vowels /ʉ, ʉ̃/ with their unrounded counterparts /ɨ, ɨ̃/. Furthermore, many speakers exhibit a secondary merger of /ɨ, ɨ̃/ with other vowels (such as /i, ĩ/ or /ə/) depending on the surrounding phonetic environment.

2.3 Phonotactics

Shasvin phonotactics are governed by strict constraints on syllable structure, vowel distribution, and the resolution of unstable semivowel sequences.

2.3.1 Syllable Structure and Clusters

The maximal syllable structure in Shasvin is **CCVCC**.

- **Onset Clusters:** Permitted clusters are restricted to /Cj, Cw/ and the liquid clusters /pr, tr, kr, mr/.
- **Coda Clusters:** Only permitted word-finally. These consist of /s, l/ followed by /p, t, k/, or /r, j, w/ followed by /p, t, k, m, n, ɸ/.
- **Intervocalic Clusters:** Medial clusters allow any coda /p, t, k, m, s, w, l, r, j/ followed by any valid onset, with the exception of plosive-plosive clusters (e.g., */pt, */kd/).

2.3.2 Phonological Distribution

- **Hiatus:** Internal hiatus is strictly forbidden; all adjacent vowel sequences must resolve according to the Vowel Combination rules shown in section 3.10.
- **Vowel Grade Environments:** Strong vowels /a, e, i, o, u/ cannot occur before a consonant cluster. Conversely, weak vowels /ə, ɛ, ɪ, ɔ, ʊ/ are barred from occurring before /ɸ/ or intervocalic /p, t, k/.
- **Lexical Constraints:**
  - **Initial:** A word may begin with any phoneme except /z, ʑ, r/, or the sequence /ʊ/ + plosive + vowel.
  - **Final:** Words may end in any vowel except /ɔ/, or the consonants /p, t, k, m, n, ɲ, ɸ, s, r, l, j, w, ɕ, ʑ, t͡s, t͡ɕ/.

2.3.3 Semivowel Resolution

Some semivowel-vowel sequences have a specific allophonic resolution.

Sequence	**Realization**	**__V**	**V__**
/wu, uw, wʊ, ʊw/	[u]	[wV]	[Vw]
/wũ, ũw/	[ũ]	[ũ̯V]	[Vũ̯]
/ji, jɪ/	[i]	[jV]	[Vj]
/jĩ/	[ĩ]	[ĩ̯V]	[Vĩ̯]
/ij, ɪj/	[ɛj]	[i.jV, ɪ.jV]	—

3 Orthography

The Shasvin script can be transliterated with 20 letters that represent its 45 phonemes. This is the byproduct of extensive phonological evolution and frozen orthography. Although it is impossible to know how to spell a new word based on its pronunciation, it is very easy to derive the pronunciation for a new word based on its spelling once you get familiar with the following rules.

3.1 The Alphabet

Letter	**Name**	**Letter**	**Name**
A	ah /a/	L	lal /ləw/
B	pap tof /paɸ to/	M	mam /mãw/
D	tat tof /təs to/	N	nan /nã/
E	e /ɛ/	O	o /ɔ/
F	faf tof /ha to/	P	pap /paɸ/
G	kik tof /t͡ɕɛj to/	R	rar /həl/
H	hah /ha/	S	sas /səɕ/
I	ih /i/	T	tat /təs/
J	ja /jə/ or jaj /jəʑ/	U	uh /u/
K	kik /t͡ɕɛj/	W	wa /wə/

Table 2: Shasvin Alphabet (Latin Order)

Special Letter: The letter **Ng** (*ngang* /ka/) is often excluded from the alphabet as it is rarely used. It is transcribed as ⟨ng⟩ because it represented /ŋ/ in Parkjol Saspine (Old Shasvin). It is pronounced /k/ word-initially and is silent elsewhere.

Table 2 uses latin alphabetical order for easier readability. However, the actual ordering of the alphabet is: J, T, N, K, R, F, W, S, P, M, O, U, L, I, A, H, E, B, D, G, NG.

This order is why ⟨jatanki⟩ /jə’tãt͡ɕi/ is the word for alphabet, often generalized to writing system, in Shasvin.

3.2 Word-final Consonants

One of the most distinguishing features of Shasvin orthography is the effect of a word-final, silent ⟨e⟩ on final consonants. For each consonant ending ⟨C⟩, there is a matching ending ⟨Ce⟩ with a different pronunciation. These pronunciation pairs are shown in Table 3.

Letter	**⟨C⟩**	**Example**	**⟨Ce⟩**	**Example**
p /p/	/ɸ/	ip /iɸ/	/p/	tihape /t͡sap/
t /t/	/s/	tihat /t͡səs/	/t/	tihato[1] /t͡sət/
k /k/	/j/	ahak /aj/	/k/	ahako[1] /ak/
m /m/	/Ṽw/	elmam /ˈɛlmãw/	/m/	ime /ɛm/
n /n/	/Ṽ/	an /ã/	/n/	ane /an/
s /s/	/ç/	hos /hɔç/	/r/	sese /sɛr/
r /h/	/l/	hadar /ˈhadəl/	/r/	hadara[1] /ˈhadər/
l /l/	/w/	upal /bəw/	/l/	—
w /w/	/w/	—	/ɸ/	—
j /j/	/ʑ/	ikej /ɪˈkɛʑ/	/j/	—

Table 3: Word-final Consonant Alternations

[1]: Sometimes, some morphemes can behave like a word-final silent ⟨e⟩ even if they are spelled with a different vowel, like the *-o* or *∼V* suffixes (see §**??** and **??**).

3.3 Plosives

The letters ⟨**p t k**⟩ are /**p t k**/ by default. They aspirate when followed by ⟨**h f**⟩ except for the case of ⟨**pf**⟩ /**ɸ**/. The sequences ⟨**up ut uk**⟩ are pronounced as /**b d g**/ when word-initially and followed by a vowel or semivowel, these phonemes are ⟨**b d g**⟩ everywhere else. These changes are summarized in Table 4 along with some other interactions.

Letter	**⟨_h⟩**	**⟨_f⟩**	**⟨#u_V-⟩**	**⟨CC⟩**	**⟨-C#⟩**	**⟨-Ce#⟩**
p /p/	⟨ph⟩ /pʰ/	⟨pf⟩ /ɸ/	⟨upV-⟩ /bV/	⟨pp⟩ /ɸ/	⟨-p⟩ /ɸ/	⟨-pe⟩ /p/
t /t/	⟨th⟩ /tʰ/	⟨tf⟩ /tʰ/	⟨utV-⟩ /dV/	⟨tt⟩ /t͡s/	⟨-t⟩ /s/	⟨-te⟩ /t/
k /k/	⟨kh⟩ /kʰ/	⟨kf⟩ /kʰ/	⟨ukV-⟩ /gV/	⟨kk⟩ /t͡ɕ/	⟨-k⟩ /j/	⟨-ke⟩ /k/

Table 4: Pronunciation of plosives.

3.4 Rhotics and Sibilants

⟨r⟩ is pronounced as /r/ everywhere except word-initially, where it is pronounced /h/, and word-finally, where it is /l/. ⟨s⟩ is always pronounced as s except in between vowels and semivowels, where it is sonorized to /z/. These rules and some other interactions are shown on Table 5.

Letter	**⟨#_⟩**	**⟨V_V⟩**	**⟨CC⟩**	**⟨_h⟩/⟨_f⟩**	**⟨sr⟩**	**⟨-C#⟩**	**⟨-Ce#⟩**
r /r/	⟨r-⟩ /h/	⟨VrV⟩ /r/	⟨rr⟩ /h/	⟨rh/rf⟩ /r/	⟨sr⟩ /h/	⟨-r⟩ /l/	⟨-re⟩ /r/
s /s/	⟨s-⟩ /s/	⟨VsV⟩ /z/	⟨ss⟩ /s/	⟨sh/sf⟩ /s/	—	⟨-s⟩ /ç/	⟨-se⟩ /r/

Table 5: Pronunciation of rhotics and sibilants.

3.5 Word-final Clusters

Some clusters can occur at the end of a word due to a silent ⟨e⟩. The only permitted clusters are /s l/ followed by /p t k/; and /r j w/ followed by /p t k m n ɸ/ (see §2.3.1). All other clusters are simplified to only the first sound.

For example, the word ⟨kopfre⟩, originally divisible into syllables as ⟨kop-fre⟩, is pronounced as /koɸ/ and not */koɸr/ as the spelling suggests.

The ending ⟨-lil⟩ will also produce an illegal cluster /jw/ if placed after a vowel. Something like ⟨amelil⟩ suggests [amɛjw] because ⟨li⟩ becomes /j/ after a vowel and ⟨l⟩ becomes /w/ word-finally. This illegal cluster is resolved as /jʊ/, i.e. /amɛjʊ/.

3.6 Silent Consonants

- **⟨h⟩ and ⟨f⟩** are always pronounced the same. At the start of a word, they are pronounced /h/ and they are silent in all other positions.
- **⟨l⟩** in ⟨Cl⟩ clusters is normally silent. However, it is pronounced as /r/ if the preceding consonant is /p t k m/, except in the specific cases of ⟨tli⟩ and ⟨kli⟩, which are pronounced /ti/ and /ki/.
- **⟨ng⟩** is pronounced as /k/ word-initially and is silent elsewhere.

3.7 Yod Sequences

- **⟨tl⟩** is pronounced /j/, except before ⟨i⟩ as ⟨tli⟩ is pronounced /ti/.
- **⟨nh⟩ and ⟨nf⟩** are pronounced /j/ between vowels, and /n/ elsewhere. In the specific sequence ⟨Vnhe#⟩ or ⟨Vnfe#⟩, the entire sequence is realized as a nasal vowel /Ṽ/.
- **⟨nhi⟩ and ⟨nfi⟩** are always /j/ after a vowel, and /nɪ/ elsewhere.

3.8 Palatalization

The sounds /t d k g n s z l/ palatalize to /t͡s d͡z t͡ɕ d͡ʑ ɲ ɕ ʑ j/ when followed by ⟨j⟩ or ⟨i⟩, like shown in Table 6. In the latter case, the /i/ sound drops if followed by another vowel (ignoring any silent ⟨h⟩ or ⟨f⟩).

Letter	⟨_j⟩	Result	⟨_i⟩ ⟨_ih⟩ ⟨_if⟩	Result
t /t/	⟨tj⟩	/t͡s/	⟨ti tih tif⟩	/t͡s(i)/
d /d/[1]	⟨dj⟩	/d͡z/[2]	⟨di dih dif⟩	/d͡z(i)/
k /k/	⟨kj⟩	/t͡ɕ/	⟨ki kih kif⟩	/t͡ɕ(i)/
g /g/[1]	⟨gj⟩	/d͡ʑ/[2]	⟨gi gih gif⟩	/d͡ʑ(i)/
n /n/	⟨nj⟩	/ɲ/	⟨ni nih nif⟩	/ɲ(i)/
s /s/	⟨sj⟩	/ɕ/	⟨si sih sif⟩	/ɕ(i)/
z /z/	⟨VsjV⟩	/ʑ/	⟨Vsi Vsih Vsif⟩	/ʑ(i)/
l /l/	⟨lj⟩	/j/	⟨li lih lif⟩	/j(i)/

Table 6: Palatalization Rules

[**1**]**:** /d g/ can also be represented by ⟨ut⟩ and ⟨uk⟩ word-initially; the sequences ⟨uti-⟩, ⟨utj-⟩, ⟨uki-⟩, and ⟨ukj-⟩ will palatalize in the same way, yielding /d͡z/ and /d͡ʑ/.

[**2**]**:** /d͡z/ and /d͡ʑ/ are pronounced as [t͡s] and [t͡ɕ] when at the end of a word.

3.8.1 Breaking Palatal Combinations

The phonemes /t d k g n s z l/ can still appear before /j/ and /ɪ i ĩ/ unpalatalized through the use of "breaker" letters:

- **Silent ⟨h⟩ or ⟨f⟩:** Placed between the consonant and the ⟨i⟩ or ⟨j⟩. These break palatalization unless they are part of another combination like ⟨thi⟩ /tʰɪ/ or ⟨anfi⟩ /aj/, i.e. ⟨shi⟩ /sɪ/, not /ɕi/.
- **Silent ⟨l⟩:** Placed between the consonant and the ⟨i⟩ or ⟨j⟩, i.e. ⟨tlia⟩ /tjə/, not /t͡sə/.
- **Silent ⟨a⟩:** Placed between the consonant and an ⟨i⟩. The vowel combination usually results in the ⟨a⟩ dropping, i.e. ⟨kai⟩ /ki/, not /t͡ɕi/.

3.9 Single Vowels

The pronunciation of Shasvin vowels is determined by the surrounding letters and sounds. Each letter gliph has three possible pronunciations named Weak, Strong, and Nasal. They are pronounced as weak by default and can be strengthened or nasalized based on the proceeding letters.

Letter	**Weak**	**Strong**	**Nasal**	**Exceptions**
⟨a⟩	/ə/	/a/	/ã/	—
⟨e⟩	/ɛ/	/e/	/ẽ/	Pronounced /ə/ at end of monosyllables.
⟨i⟩	/ɪ/	/i/	/ĩ/	See Note below.
⟨o⟩	/ɔ/	/o/	/õ/	⟨o⟩ is /ʊ/ at the end of a word.
⟨u⟩	/ʊ/	/u/	/ũ/	—

Table 7: Shasvin Vowel Grades

Note: ⟨i⟩ /ɪ/ strengthens to /i/ after palatals or silent ⟨l⟩ and is silent between a palatal and a vowel. It is realized as /ɛ/ before coda /j/ and in stressed syllables.

Vowel Strengthening

A vowel strengthens to its **Strong** grade when followed by:

- A silent ⟨h⟩ or ⟨f⟩.
- The sound /ɸ/ (spelled ⟨pp⟩, ⟨pf⟩, word-final ⟨-p⟩, or ⟨-we⟩).
- An intervocalic voiceless plosive ⟨p t k⟩ (if the following vowel is not a silent ⟨e⟩).
- The negative imperfective suffix *-pe*.
- The sequence ⟨nh⟩ or ⟨nf⟩ when pronounced as /j/.
- ⟨a⟩ can strengthen to /a/ in some stressed syllables even if the previous conditions are not met.

Vowel Nasalization

- The sequences ⟨an en in on un⟩ are pronounced /ã ẽ ĩ õ ũ/ unless the ⟨n⟩ is followed by a semi/vowel or part of an ⟨nh nf nli⟩ sequence.
- ⟨nh nf⟩ do nasalize the previous vowel, however, if followed by a word-final silent ⟨e⟩.
- Word-final ⟨am em im om um⟩ are realized as /ãw ẽw ĩw õw ũw/.

3.10 Vowel Combinations

In Shasvin, any sequence of two or more adjacent vowels is resolved into either a single vowel phoneme or a glide–vowel sequence. Resolution follows a fixed hierarchy of rules applied in order of priority (top to bottom in Table 8). In sequences of three or more vowels, higher-priority rules apply first; remaining combinations are then resolved from left to right.

Pattern	**Result**	**Example**	**Exceptions**	**Example**
⟨uV⟩	/wV/			
⟨uHV⟩	/wV/			
⟨oV⟩	/wV/		⟨oi⟩ → /ɨ/	⟨ajoip⟩ /əjɨɸ/
⟨oHV⟩	/wV/	⟨tofel⟩ /twɛw/	⟨oHo⟩ → /wɔ/; but ⟨oHoX⟩ → /o/	
⟨iV⟩	/jV/		⟨iiX⟩ → /ji/; but ⟨ii⟩ → /ɪ/	
⟨iHV⟩	/jV/			
⟨aV⟩	/V/			
⟨Va⟩	/V/			
⟨aHV$_a$⟩	/ɨ/	⟨sahil⟩ /sɨw/	⟨aHa⟩ → /a/	
⟨eV$_a$⟩	/ɨ/		⟨ee⟩ → /ɛ/	
⟨eHV$_a$⟩	/ɨ/		⟨eHeX⟩ → /e/	
⟨aHV$_o$⟩	/ʉ/			
⟨eV$_o$⟩	/ʉ/			
⟨eHV$_o$⟩	/ʉ/			

Table 8: Vowel Combination Priorities

V is ⟨a e i o u⟩. **V**$_a$ is ⟨a e i⟩. **V**$_o$ is ⟨o u⟩.
H is a silent ⟨h⟩ or ⟨f⟩. **X** is a vowel strengthening sequence.

3.10.1 Nasalization in Vowel Combinations

The rules for glides and ⟨a⟩-dropping work the same if the second vowel is nasalized. The only exceptions to note for nasalization in vowel combinations are the following:

- If the second vowel of a sequence that resolved into /ɨ/ or /ʉ/ was nasalized, the resulting vowels are /ɨ̃/ and /ʉ̃/ instead.
- When any vowel is followed by a nasalized ⟨e⟩, the ⟨e⟩ is absorbed and the preceding vowel is nasalized.
  - Example: ⟨o(H)eN⟩ → /õ/ (cf. ⟨tofen⟩ /tõ/)

4 Syntax

4.1 Constituent Order

Standard Shasvin follows **VSO** word order.

(1)

aj	**larruk**	**tokkeful**
əʐ	ˈlahʊj	ˈtɔt͡ɕʉw
eat	snail	flower

‘The snail eats the flower.’

(2)

jut-o	**utiibi**	**tahrik**	**apa**
jʊt	ˈd͡zɛbɪ	ˈtarɛj	ˈapə
see-NPRS	woman	dress	3POSS

‘The woman saw her dress.’

The indirect object of a sentence is marked with the dative case suffix ⟨**-n**⟩ applied to the last word of the noun phrase (see §4.2.2) and is generally placed after the direct object.

(3)

kel	**ang**	**tof**	**utiibi-n**
kɛw	a	to	ˈd͡zɛbĩ
give	1S	wood	woman-DAT

‘I give the wood to the woman.’

(4)

pek-o	**ibi**	**tibi**	**apa-n**
pɛk	ɪˈbɛ	ˈt͡sɛbɪ	apã
speak-NPRS	person	small.one	3POSS-DAT

‘The person spoke to their baby.’

However, pronouns for the DO and IO—i.e. patientive and dative pronouns—are preverbal clitics (see §5.1.1). This means Shasvin’s word order is more accurately **oVSO**.

(5)

la= s’=kel	**ang**
ləsˈkɛw	a
3DAT= 3PAT=give	1S

‘I give it to them.’

(6)

la= pek-o	**ibi**
ləˈpɛk	ɪˈbɛ
3DAT= speak-NPRS	person

‘The person spoke to them.’

Sentences with multiple verbs generally follow $\mathbf{V_1SoV_2O}$, with $\mathbf{V_2}$ in nominalized form acting as the object of $\mathbf{V_1}$ and taking its own object as a preverbal clitic or a noun phrase placed after it. If one of the verbs is an auxiliary, however, the word order becomes **oAuxSVO**, with the main verb nominalized and the auxiliary pulling any object clitic to the front.

(7)

tor	**ang**	**s’=jut-al**
tɔl	a	ˈsjʊtəw
want	1S	3PAT=see-NMLZ

‘I want to see it.’

(8)

s’=ahak-o	**ang**	**kel-al**	**kjol**
sak	a	ˈkɛləw	t͡ɕɔw
2DAT=NEG-NPRS	1S	give-NMLZ	time

‘I didn’t give you time.’

4.2 The Noun Phrase

4.2.1 Internal structure

Noun phrases are predominantly head-initial, with the lexical noun followed by its modifiers, such as demonstratives and attributive nouns. The sole exception to this generalization is a possessor marked with the genitive case, which precedes the possessed noun.

(9)	**utiibi**	**amel-il**	**ipo-ntep**	**tahrik**	**laha**	**ina**
	ˈd͡zɛbɪ	əˈmɛjʊ	ˈɛpõteɸ	ˈtarɛj	la	ˈɛnə
	woman	be.pretty-NMLZ	1POSS-GEN	dress	tall	DEM.PROX

‘This long dress of my beautiful wife.’

4.2.2 Case marking

Shasvin noun phrases are marked for three cases: *direct*, *dative*, and *genitive*.

Noun phrases occur in the direct case by default. The dative case is marked by the suffix ⟨**-n**⟩, while the genitive is marked by ⟨**-ntep**⟩, following the rules outlined in Table 9. Although the table illustrates only the dative case, the same processes apply to the genitive. Orthographically, the genitive looks like the dative form followed by ⟨**-tep**⟩.

Word ending	Process	Examples (Base > Case-Marked)
-V[1]	add -*n*	anfa /ˈ**ajə**/ > anfan /ˈ**ajã**/ hoso /**hɔr**/ > hoson /ˈ**hɔzõ**/[2]
-C	replace with -*n*	hadar /ˈ**hadəl**/ > hadan /ˈ**hadã**/ tofel /**twɛw**/ > tofen /**tõ**/
-Ce	replace with -*n*	jute /**jʊt**/ > jun /**jũ**/
-C_1C_2e	replace with -C_1*in*	jarpe /**jərp**/ > jarin /ˈ**jərĩ**/ matje /**mat͡s**/ > matin /ˈ**mat͡sĩ**/

Table 9: Dative Case Marking Process by Word Ending

[**1**]**:** Except ⟨**e**⟩ if silent.
[**2**]**:** The ~V morpheme, which marks indefiniteness in nouns by replicating the vowel in the last syllable and is normally treated like a word-final, silent ⟨**-e**⟩ (see §5.2.1), is treated as a normal vowel when applying the dative or genitive suffixes, which can affect the pronunciation of the final consonant.

These suffixes are attached to the final word of the noun phrase, which may be a noun, a modifier, or another constituent.

4.3 Copular Sentences

In Standard Shasvin, copular predication is expressed by a verbal negative copula *ahak*, which is the same verb used as a negative auxiliary (see § 5.4.3). Affirmative copular meaning is obtained by negating this verb with the prefix *pa-*, yielding *paahak*. When unmarked for tense or aspect, this affirmative copula is commonly omitted, resulting in a zero-copula construction.

(10)

ahak	**se**	**larruk~ke**
aj	sə	ˈlahʊt͡ɕ
NEG	3S	snail~INDF

'It is not a snail.'

(11)

pa-ahak	**se**	**larruk~ke**
paj	sə	ˈlahʊt͡ɕ
NEG-NEG	3S	snail~INDF

'It is a snail.'

(12)

se	**larruk~ke**
sə	ˈlahʊt͡ɕ
3S	snail~INDF

'It is a snail.'

Since the copula is a verb, it can be marked for tense and aspect to express other verbal times (see §).

(13)

ahak-o	**se**	**larruk~ke**
ak	sə	ˈlahʊt͡ɕ
NEG-NPRS	3S	snail~INDF

'It wasn't a snail.'

(14)

neh	**se**	**pa-ahak-al**	**larruk~ke**
ne	sə	ˈpakəw	ˈlahʊt͡ɕ
FUT	3S	NEG-NEG-NMLZ	snail~INDF

'It will be a snail.'

5 Morphology

5.1 Pronouns

5.1.1 Personal Pronouns

Shasvin pronouns can be marked for four cases: Agentive (AGT), Patientive (PAT), Dative (DAT), and Genitive (GEN). Agentive and genitive pronouns are stressed words that have different versions for singular and plural, while patientive and dative pronouns are preverbal clitics and do not make a number distinction. Table 10 excludes genitive pronouns since they are just the agentive ones with a suffix applied and will be addressed later.

<table>
<tr><th rowspan="2">Person</th><th rowspan="2">Type</th><th colspan="3">AGT</th><th rowspan="2">PAT</th><th rowspan="2">DAT</th></tr>
<tr><th>Sg.</th><th>Pl. (Exc)</th><th>Pl. (Inc)</th></tr>
<tr><td>1st</td><td>—</td><td>ang /a/</td><td>ane /an/</td><td>anak /ˈanəj/</td><td>n(a) /n(ə)/</td><td>j(u) /j(ʊ)/</td></tr>
<tr><td rowspan="2">2nd</td><td>Casual</td><td>ngak /kaj/</td><td colspan="2">akje /at͡ɕ/</td><td>ng(a) /k(ə)/</td><td>s(u) /s(ʊ)/</td></tr>
<tr><td>Formal</td><td>ip /iɸ/</td><td colspan="2">pip /piɸ/</td><td>i(p) /ɪ~iɸ/</td><td rowspan="2">l(a) /l(ə)/</td></tr>
<tr><td rowspan="2">3rd</td><td>Animate[a]</td><td colspan="3">ina /ˈɛnə/ ~ ila /ˈɛlə/</td><td>up(a) /b(ə)/</td></tr>
<tr><td>Inanimate</td><td>se /sə/</td><td colspan="2">sese /sɛr/</td><td>s(a) /s(ə)/</td><td>e(k) /ɛ(j)/</td></tr>
</table>

[a] There are no agentive animate third-person pronouns; demonstratives are used instead (see §5.1.3).

Table 10: Shasvin Personal Pronouns by Person, Number, Case, Formality, and Animacy.

Pronominal clitics are written as separate words but phonologically attach to the verb, forming a single prosodic word. Optional vowels in clitics are used only if the resulting word would break a phonotactic rule without it; otherwise, they are dropped. Similarly, *ek* drops ⟨k⟩ before another consonant and *ip* drops ⟨p⟩ in all environments except before ⟨i⟩ or ⟨j⟩. These reduced forms are indicated with an apostrophe in place of the dropped letter and following space, as in sentence 15.

The agentive and patientive cases are used for the agent and the patient of a transitive verb respectively. Shasvin pronouns follow **active-stative alignment** since the subject of an intransitive verb can be marked with the agentive case to indicate a degree of volition, or with the patientive case to indicate the lack thereof.

(15) **up'=jut-o** **ang**
bjʊt a
3PAT=see-NPRS 1S.AGT
'I saw them.'

(16) **na= las-o**
nəˈlər
1PAT= lose-NPRS
'I lost.'

(17) **las-o** **ang**
lər a
lose-NPRS 1S.AGT
'I lost on purpose.'

The order for pronouns in a ditransitive sentence is **DAT-PAT-V-AGT**.

(18) **sa= pek ila ibi-n**
sə'pɛj 'ɛlə ɪ'bĩ
3PAT= say DEM person-DAT
'He says it to the person.'

(19) **ju= s'=pek ila**
jʊs'pɛj 'ɛlə
1DAT= 3PAT=say DEM
'He says it to me.'

Sentence 18 uses the full form of ⟨sa⟩ because /sp/ is an illegal cluster word-initially. In Sentence 19, the reduced form is used because the same cluster is permitted between syllables (see §2.3.1).

Genitive Pronouns

Genitive pronouns derive from the Old Shasvin construction *A et ep B*—meaning *B exists with A*—which contracted into the suffix -ntep attached to agentive pronouns, yielding the forms in Table 11.

The first-person genitive has the same form for both singular and plural-exclusive.

Second-person genitives do not distinguish formality as the genitive pronouns were formed during an earlier stage of the language, which used *ip* and *pip* as animate third-person agentive pronouns and had not yet shifted their meaning to a formal second person.

		GEN		
Person	**Type**	**Sg.**	**Pl. (Exc)**	**Pl. (Inc)**
1st	—	*antep* /'ãteɸ/		*anintep* /a'ɲĩteɸ/
2nd	—	*ngantep* /'kãteɸ/	*akintep* /a'ť͡ɕĩteɸ/	
3rd	Animate	*intep* /'ĩteɸ/	*pintep* /'pĩteɸ/	
	Inanimate	*sentep* /'sẽteɸ/		

Table 11: Shasvin Genitive Pronouns by Person, Number, and Type.

Genitive pronouns replace a noun phrase that denotes a *possessed entity*. In Classical Shasvin, they also functioned as possessive determiners, replacing the *possessor*, but this role is now fulfilled by borrowed determiners from Kupina Hala (see §5.3.3).

(20) **aj-o larruk ipo ngantep**
əj 'lahʊj 'ɛpʊ 'kãteɸ
eat-NPRS snail 1POSS 2S.GEN
'My snail ate yours.'

5.1.2 Reflexive pronouns

5.1.3 Demonstratives

Traditionally, the four Shasvin demonstrative pronouns encode both distance from the speaker and distance from the listener, like shown on Table 12. Most speakers nowadays, however, have simplified this into a two distance system with *ina* and *ila*.

	Close to Listener	**Far From Listener**
Close to Speaker	*ina* /ˈɛnə/	*inela* /ɪˈnɛlə/
Far From Speaker	*ilane* /ɪˈlan/	*ila* /ˈɛlə/

Table 12: Shasvin demonstratives

These demonstratives can be used in place of objects and people. This latter use is actually the standard way of referencing people as Shasvin lacks dedicated third person animate pronouns. Since demonstratives do not encode number or gender, this usage does not make a difference between one or many people. This is something also seen with patientive and dative pronouns (see §5.1.1).

Because of the implicit distance, *ina* is usually used to refer to people who are present or visible to the speaker, whereas *ila* is used for people who are absent or out of sight.

(21) **ina** **hadar~a**
ˈɛnə ˈhadər
DEM house~INDF
'this is a house'

(22) **jut-o** **ang** **ila**
jʊt a ˈɛlə
see-NPRS 1S DEM
'I saw that.'

Note: Sentence 22 could also be translated as *I saw those*, *I saw him*, *I saw her*, or *I saw them.* These possible meanings are disambiguated through context.

5.2 Nouns

5.2.1 Definiteness

Nouns in Shasvin are definite by default and can be marked for indefiniteness by a suffix that comes from historical reduplication and, therefore, depends on the root's ending. The derivation rules are shown in Table 13.

Ending	**Add**	**Examples**
-p, -t, -k	~pe, ~te, ~ke	*larruk* /ˈlahʊj/ → *larrukke* /ˈlahʊt͡ɕ/
-VV	–	–
-VC	~V[1]	*hadar* /ˈhadəl/ → *hadara* /ˈhadər/ (as if it were *hadare**)
		ful /hʊw/ [hu] → *fulu* /hʊl/ (as if it were *fule**)
		seh /se/ → *sehe* /se/
-CV	~C[2]	*ibi* /ɪˈbɛ/ → *ibip* /ɪˈbiɸ/
$-C_1C_2V$	$\sim C_2$ (or $\sim C_1$)[3]	*anfa* /ˈajə/ → *anfaf* /ˈaja/
		matje /mat͡s/ → *matjat* /ˈmat͡səs/

Table 13: Indefinite form derivation rules based on root ending.

[1]: The ~V morpheme is treated as a word-final, silent ⟨-e⟩. It changes ⟨-Vm -Vn -s -r -l -j -w⟩ /Ṽw Ṽ ɕ l w ʑ w/ to /Vm Vn r r l j ɸ/.
[2]: If C is ⟨b d g⟩ it changes to ⟨p t k⟩. If V is ⟨e⟩ it changes to ⟨a⟩.
[3]: Although ⟨$-C_1C_2V$⟩ mainly becomes ⟨$-C_1C_2VC_2$⟩, it might become ⟨$-C_1C_2VC_1$⟩ instead if C_2 is ⟨l r w j f⟩ and C_1C_2 were part of the same onset in Old Shasvin. If V is ⟨e⟩ it changes to ⟨a⟩.

5.3 Adnominal Modifiers

5.3.1 Adjectives

Adjectives describe properties of nouns and typically appear after the noun they modify.

(23)

upal~li	**utiibi**	**jarpe**
ˈbəli	ˈd͡zɛbɪ	jərp
come~IPF	woman	good

‘The good woman is coming.’

(24)

pe~pek	**ang**	**hibi**	**laha-n**
ˈpepɛj	a	hɪˈbɛ	lã
speak\~IPF	1S	man	tall-DAT

‘I’m speaking to the tall man.’

Adjectives may also function as predicates in copular sentences, expressing a property of the subject. The omission of the copula can occasionally lead to ambiguity. For example, sentence 25 could also be interpreted as *the small snail*. This is rarely a problem, but the ambiguity can be resolved by explicitly using the copula as in sentence 26 (see §4.3).

(25)

larruk	**tibi**
ˈlahʊj	t͡sɛbɪ
snail	small

‘The snail is small.’

(26)

pa-ahak	**larruk**	**tibi**
paj	ˈlahʊj	t͡sɛbɪ
NEG-NEG	snail	small

‘The snail *is* small.’

Adjectives may also occur without a noun, in which case they refer to “the one characterized by that property.” This usage is common, and some adjectives have developed specialized meanings when used in this way. For example, the adjective *tibi*, meaning “small,” may appear alone to mean “the small one,” but it is also used as the general word for “baby.”

5.3.2 Predicative Verbs

Predicative verbs are intransitive verbs that occur as predicates, expressing a property or characteristic of the subject. To use them as nominal modifiers, they are first turned into a subordinate clause through nominalization (see §??), allowing them to function as modifiers within another sentence.

(27)

amel-o	**utiibi**
əˈmɛl	ˈd͡zɛbɪ
be.pretty-NPRS	woman

‘The woman was pretty.’

(28)

tihat~hat	**utiibi**	**amel-il**	**hada-n=s**
ˈt͡sətʰəs	ˈd͡zɛbɪ	əˈmɛjʊ	ˈhadãɕ
go~IPF	woman	be.pretty-NMLZ	house\-DAT=DIR

‘The pretty woman is going home.’

5.3.3 Possessive Determiners

The possessive determiners in Shasvin were borrowed from Kupina Hala and are used in place of a *possessor* (see §5.1.1 for genitive pronouns replacing possessed entities). They are placed after the noun or noun phrase they modify and do not encode number.

<table>
<tr><th>Person</th><th>Type</th><th>Pronoun (IPA)</th></tr>
<tr><td>1st</td><td>—</td><td>ipo /ˈɛpʊ/</td></tr>
<tr><td rowspan="2">2nd</td><td>Casual</td><td>opa /ˈɔpə/</td></tr>
<tr><td>Formal</td><td rowspan="2">apa /ˈapə/</td></tr>
<tr><td rowspan="2">3rd</td><td>Animate</td></tr>
<tr><td>Inanimate</td><td>epo /ˈɛpʊ/</td></tr>
</table>

Table 14: Shasvin Possessive Determiners by Person, Formality, and Animacy.

In informal speech, these forms are sometimes reduced by dropping everything after the first vowel. This is accepted in spoken language but discouraged in writing. For linguistic purposes, however, the ellision can be represented by an apostrophe, as shown in sentence 30.

(29) **la= neh** **ang** **kel-al** **tahrik** **apa**
ləˈne a ˈkɛləw ˈtarɛj ˈapə
3DAT= FUT 1S give-NMLZ dress 3A.POSS
'I will give them their dress.'

(30) **jut-o** **ngak** **anfa** **e'**
ˈjʊt ˈkaj ˈajə ɛ
see-NPRS 2S hand 3INA.POSS
'You saw its hand(s).'

5.3.4 Demonstrative Determiners

Demonstrative pronouns in Shasvin may also function adnominally as demonstrative determiners. The same demonstrative forms described in §5.1.3 are used in both pronominal and determiner functions.

When used as determiners, demonstratives are postposed to the noun or noun phrase they modify. They do not encode number or gender, and no formal distinction is made between singular and plural referents. They only encode distance from the speaker and listener.

(31) **ahak** **hadar** **ila** **antep**
aj ˈhadəl ˈɛlə ˈãteɸ
NEG house DEM.DIST 1S.GEN
'That house is not mine.'

5.4 Verbs

Shasvin verbs are categorized into three morphological groups based on the final vowel of the original verbal stem. Although this vowel is no longer present due to historical rebracketing, it continues to condition the form of several verbal suffixes and particles.

- **Group 1:** Verbs whose original stems ended in ⟨a⟩, ⟨e⟩, or a consonant.
- **Group 2:** Verbs whose original stems ended in ⟨i⟩.
- **Group 3:** Verbs whose original stems ended in ⟨o⟩ or ⟨u⟩.

5.4.1 Tense

Shasvin verbs are in the present (PRS) tense by default and can be marked for the nonpresent (NPRS) tense by the ⟨-o⟩ suffix, which orthographically works as an ⟨e⟩ if no other suffixes are applied.

(32)

tor	**ina**	**ip= jut-al**
tɔl	ˈɛnə	iɸˈjʊtəw
want	DEM	2PAT= see-NMLZ

‘They want to see you.’

(33)

tor-o	**ina**	**ip= jut-al**
tɔr	ˈɛnə	iɸˈjʊtəw
want-NPRS	DEM	2PAT= see-NMLZ

‘They wanted to see you.’

The nonpresent tense is interpreted as a preterite past in Sentence 33 because the sentence is in the perfective aspect (see § 5.4.4)

5.4.2 Aspect

Shasvin verbs are in the perfective (PFV) aspect by default and can be marked for the imperfective (IPF) aspects with the imperfective particle, which originates from reduplication and therefore varies between verbs. The way to derive the imperfective particle is different for the three verb groups.

- **Group 1:** The rule of thumb is to read the verb as if pronounced exactly as written, then take the final syllable. If this syllable begins with ⟨b⟩, ⟨d⟩, or ⟨g⟩, the initial consonant is devoiced to ⟨p⟩, ⟨t⟩, or ⟨k⟩ respectively. For example, *tihat* /t͡səs/ would give us *hat* /həs/ and *lahabek* /labɛj/ would give us *pek* /pɛj/.

- **Groups 2 and 3:** The final consonant of the verb stem is taken and followed by ⟨i⟩ or ⟨u⟩ respectively. For example, *upal* /bəw/ would give us *li* /i/ and *aj* /əʑ/ would give us *ju* /jʊ/.

The imperfective particle can be directly suffixed to the verb, see Sentence 34, in what is called **suffixed reduplication**. If this creates two *distinct* adjacent plosives, the first one is dropped and the previous vowel is strengthened (e.g., *pek* /pɛj/ → *pepek* /pepɛj/, not **pekpek*). This is the most common and accepted usage.

Alternatively, the imperfective particle can be used as a clitic that attaches to the end of the sentence, see Sentence 35, in what is called **cliticized reduplication**. Although this is also grammatically correct, it is rarely used outside of colloquial spoken language.

(34) **tihat-has ang hada-n=s**
ˈt͡sətʰəs a ˈhadãɕ
go-IPF 1S house\-DAT=DIR
'I'm going home.'

(35) **aj ang larruk~ke ju**
əʐ̊ a ˈlahʊt͡ɕ jʊ
eat 1S snail~INDF IPF
'I'm eating a snail.'

These sentences are interpreted to be in the present continuous because the verbs are in the present tense (see § 5.4.4)

5.4.3 Negation

Negation in Shasvin is conditioned by aspect and verb type, which means there is not a single formula that can be applied uniformly across all sentences. Verbs are perfective by default (see § 5.4.2), so we will start with perfective negation before moving to imperfective negation.

Perfective Negation Perfective clauses are negated using one of two negative auxiliary verbs. The specific auxiliary to be used depends on the semantics of the main verb:

- **osih** /ˈɔʒi/ 'to stop' — used with verbs of motion
- **ahak** /aj/ 'to fail' — used with all other verbs

In addition, the prefix **pa-** /p(ə)/ is used to negate auxiliary verbs, or the main verb in a sentece with multiple verbs, to avoid introducing yet another verb.

(36) **osih ang tihat-al**
ˈɔʒi a ˈt͡sətəw
NEG 1S go-NMLZ
'I don't go.'

(37) **ahak ang aj-ul**
aj a ˈəjʊw
NEG 1S eat-NMLZ
'I don't eat.'

(38) **pator ang aj-ul**
pəˈtɔl a ˈəjʊw
NEG-want 1S eat-NMLZ
'I don't want to eat.'

Imperfective Negation Imperfective clauses do not use a negative auxiliary. Instead, negation is expressed with the suffix ⟨-(e)pe⟩ /(ɛ)p/, borrowed from Kupina Hala. This suffix inherently encodes both negation and imperfective aspect, and therefore the imperfective particle (see § 5.4.2) is not used in negative clauses.

When this suffix is added to a verb ending in ⟨t⟩ or ⟨k⟩, the final consonant is deleted and the preceding vowel is strengthened. In all other environments, the suffix attaches regularly, with epenthesis only when required to not break a phonotactical rule.

(39)

aj-pe	**ang**	**larruk~ke**
ˈəjp	a	ˈlahʊt͡ɕ
eat-NEG.IPF	1S	snail~INDF

‘I’m not eating a snail.’

(40)

tiha-pe	**ang**
ˈt͡sap	a
go\-NEG.IPF	1S

‘I’m not going.’

5.4.4 Tense–Aspect Interaction